

Media Aesthetics: Text

Paper # 3

For your final paper assignment, you are asked to write a **1200 to 1500**-word essay by choosing **at least ONE** item from the following list:

- *The Tempest*
- *Rashomon*
- *Fun Home*
- *Arrival*

You may combine TWO items from the above list. If you chose this option, your paper must focus on a **media comparison** between your chosen media objects (for e.g. *Tempest* vs *Rashomon*, or *Fun Home* vs *Rashomon* etc).

Remember that the goal of the assignment is to offer an interesting thesis to your reader about your text. As in previous assignments, you are required to use the theoretical concepts we've explored together this quarter in writing your essay.

-Keywords. Some examples of keywords you may want to use include the following (this is not an exhaustive list; you can extract your own keywords from the theoretical texts also):

Signifier (Representamen)/ Signified (Interpretant)/ Object; icon/index/symbol; system/environment; binary coding (self-referential binary code used by a system); first and second-order observation; constative/performative; binary opposition (metaphysics); pharmakon (oscillating sign) in Stiegler; transcendental signified (Cary Wolfe); iterability (Derrida); memory (Stiegler).

You may use **up to six keywords** from **two sources** (for e.g. Chandler on Saussure/ Peirce; Barthes on authorship; or the essay on "Systems" by Wellbery, or on language and systems by Wolfe; Plato on signs, speech/writing or memory; Culler and/or Derrida on communication and iterability (or performativity), or the pharmakon (the oscillating sign that troubles binary oppositions according to Derrida like presence/absence or speech/writing). It is a good idea to limit your keyword selection initially to a couple of keywords.

Second, whatever keywords you use in your essay should be **defined** and presented to the reader with the proper **quotes and citations** from your chosen source(s). Third, the keywords you will use (as well as your source) should be presented in your **introduction**. However, this does not mean that you need to exhaustively define your keywords in the introduction, only that you are to provide your reader with an initial definition of your keyword(s). You can amplify the keyword(s), extend and develop them in the body paragraphs. Note that in defining your

keywords you are to avoid using lengthy blockquotes. This is because you are acting as a guide to your reader (explaining, summarizing, interpreting), giving him or her information about the keyword(s) from the text. And you also need to tell your reader how you are going to apply the term(s) to your object of analysis (**relevance** of the keyword(s) to your image or text).

First Option: Drawing on Background Sources

-You may draw on background materials for your essay (for e.g. *Fun Home* the musical), or interviews with Bechdel, Nolan, or Villeneuve if that helps you. However, you are not required to draw on any performance or background material. It is up to you to decide what works best in light of your definition of a problem for which you will provide some kind of answer in the paper. And also note that drawing on any such background material should contribute to enriching your own ideas, not substituting for them. For instance, if you decide to cite an interview with Bechdel, Nolan, or Villeneuve, you should not take what they say about their work at face value, as the final word on what it means. Rather, your task would be to cite them and incorporate what they say (even go against it if need be) to put forward your own interpretation. You can think of the background material as something that would enrich your understanding of the work. In this regard, a potentially productive approach would be to examine what the authors say about the **aesthetic form** of the work (its formal arrangement, the way the parts are organized together), as opposed to its content. Villeneuve, Nolan, and Bechdel have commented in online interviews on such formal aspects of their work, revealing to the audience the process of construction of their visual narratives. Think about what this means in relation to the texts: how is this unveiling of the creative process an extension of the story-worlds presented in *Fun Home*, or *Interstellar*, or *Arrival*?

-A second possibility: alternatively, your background source can be a **scholarly article** written about your chosen text. If you choose this route, your goal should be to assess an interpretive claim (one is enough) made in the scholarly article you are using about your text, and to explore the limits of that interpretation, and offer the reader one which is different. This is to say, **your interpretation takes precedence** over the source you are citing. You should not cite the article to confirm your interpretation, but rather to show why yours reveals something about the text you've chosen which your source fails to do (or does not explore sufficiently well). Here is an **example**: "While my source claims that the relationship between daughter and father in *Interstellar* is X, I argue that this claim overlooks a fundamental aspect of that relationship. The article does not take into consideration that the father/daughter relationship is explored through media of writing. If we take this point into account, we can see better that the father/daughter relationship stands as a binary for exploring the relationship between speech and writing."

One possibility for your background source could be to explore further the concept of second-order observation in systems theory. You may wish to read an essay by Luhmann that discusses the topic of second-order observation in relation to deconstruction (titled “Deconstruction as Second-Order Observing”), or his essay titled “The Paradox of Observing Systems”. Both essays can be found in *Theories of Distinction*, a book which collects several essays on second-order observation by Luhmann. Here is a link where you can access the book and the essays online:

<https://books.google.com/books?id=L0G2bwV9VMMC&printsec=frontcover&dq=theories+of+distinction&hl=en&sa=X&ved=0ahUKEwikx-X47vjgAhUC4IMKHRgiDVoQ6wEIKzAA#v=onepage&q=theories%20of%20distinction&f=false>

-Second Option: Interpret, Create/Rewrite

Alternatively, you may write a **1200-word essay** combined with a **creative one-page** submission, for example a **meme**, **comic**, or piece of **dialog** between characters based on the text you are writing about. As an example, if you write an essay about the shift from first-order to second-order observation in *Interstellar* in relation to speech/writing, your one-page meme, comic, or dialogue should be an extension of your essay, demonstrating your key claim or one of your key points in the essay.

A second possibility: that your creative submission be a **re-writing of a scene** from your chosen text (again based on your interpretation). How should the scene have played out, given your approach to the text (keywords) and your interpretation? This exercise follows from our readings this quarter (e.g. Barthes, Derrida, and Borges): as the birth of the reader in relation to text, but also as the text having many possible iterations and variations (texts are virtual, not only actual entities).

Writing: A Multi-Step Process

A main goal of the assignment is to help you acquire writing skills that will take your essay beyond class discussion (even as you draw on it). A good way to do this is to approach the assignment as a multi-step process, beginning with defining the **topic**. Start by thinking about a specific scene or two scenes in a given text. Next, look for keywords that address the types of signs, systems, modes of observation etc you see in the scene. Following that, think about the presentation in the text of the relationship between the keywords (say speech/writing, systems and signs at work in the specific context you are examining). What kind of system do the signs form together? What is the relationship between the Symbolic and the Indexical signs, the abstract and the concrete, the conceptual and the material modes of signification in the scene?

You may of course wish to consider Iconic and Indexical modes of signification as well, if this is applicable. Now inventory these different sign and systems relations in your scene.

Next write down a description of the relationship between the various signs/systems/modes of observation etc in the scene. That is, consider how the signs are parts of a larger whole (a system). How would you describe this whole? Next, consider the relationship of the character or speaker (to the system(s) and signs. How does the character relate to these system(s) and signs? What kinds of signs is the character adept at noting? Which others are overlooked, or pose problems of signification and/or interpretation for the character? Are there self-referential signs in the text? And if so, what does self-reference accomplish in the scene (what is its signifying function) in relation to the context of the sign?

Following the description of the scene, you are ready now to define your topic by examining the relationships between the various elements of your description. This step should lead you to the second element of your paper, namely defining the **question or problem** with which you will engage. The third step is to generate a **thesis** as an answer to your problem or as an argument that advances your solution for the question/problem that you posed for your paper topic.

If you approach the process of generating a paper topic and question in the above-suggested manner, you will write an essay about something which you find interesting, and around which you have defined a problem, which you would like to communicate to other people – your readers. Your thesis shows that your proposed answer to the problem you have defined for the reader is convincing, robust, and interesting. And the rest of the paper – the **body paragraphs** – unpack for the reader your main thesis and elaborate on it, supporting it with **evidence**, and exploring it in detail through **close reading** of your chosen text and/or image.

In following the above steps, your goal is ultimately to present your reader with a convincing and interesting (i.e. not readily obvious) series of points and observations about your chosen text.

Formatting:

Your paper should include a **title**, your **name**, use a **12-size font**, be **double-spaced** and **page-numbered**. Also, do not forget to include page numbers when citing texts, and to proof-read your paper for any typos or grammatical errors.

Good luck!